

OMAR ABDULLAH
Ex-CM, J&K; former Union Minister of State; Vice-president, J&K National Conference



MEHBOOBA MUFTI SAYEED
Former CM, J&K; President, Jammu and Kashmir Peoples Democratic Party



JITENDRA SINGH
Union MoS; Udhampur MP; Member, BJP national executive



TARIQ HAMEED KARRA
Former MP, Srinagar; President, J&K Pradesh Congress Committee

MOMENT OF TRUTH

Despair has been the default setting in J&K for too long, but this assembly election brings stirrings of hope. Eight prominent politicians speak to *Group Editorial Director* Raj Chengappa on their many disagreements and aspirations

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Q. What is the significance of this election?

● **OMAR ABDULLAH:** This assembly election has come after much kicking and screaming on the part of the government of India. Left to them, we wouldn't have had this election. This election has been foisted upon them by the Supreme Court ordering that it be completed before the 30th of September.

● **MEHBOOBA MUFTI:** New Delhi is trying to project as if it has done us a great favour. Despite claiming that they have improved the situation, it took 10 years to hold an election that should have been a routine thing in a democracy. That is unfortunate.

● **JITENDRA SINGH:** It is a resurgence of the democratic aspiration—we saw it in the high turnout for the recent Lok Sabha election. For the first time, people realise that they have an opportunity to elect their representatives and there will be no manipulation.